



Victorious army

NVA soldiers flying the flag of the Provisional Revolutionary Government sit atop a T-54 tank outside the Independence Palace in Saigon on April 30, 1975. The mood of the victors was relaxed after South Vietnamese troops obeyed orders to lay down their arms.

Desperate hope

South Vietnamese and American politicians kept pursuing a fantasy of settlement without surrender. US Secretary of State Henry Kissinger declared that he expected a negotiated end to the war. In Saigon, hopes focused on General Duong Van Minh, known as Big Minh. The leader of the coup that overthrew the Diem regime in 1963, Minh had lost out in the subsequent power battles between South Vietnamese generals. He advocated a “Third Force” to keep contact with the communists and seek peace on the basis of shared nationalism. On April 28, Minh was chosen to replace Huong as president, in the belief that he was the man who could reach a deal with the communists.

No more negotiations

President Minh’s inaugural speech proposed a ceasefire and a coalition government of reconciliation. Minutes after his speech, North Vietnamese pilots flying captured A-37 attack aircraft hit the city’s Tan Son Nhut airport. The timing was not planned, but effectively showed the communists’ disregard for talks. General Dung set April 29 as the day for the final assault on the city—rockets at 4 a.m. signaled the start of the action.

The only obstacle that remained to delay the North Vietnamese occupation of Saigon was the continuing American presence. Still cautious about a possible military reaction from Washington, the politburo preferred to avoid American casualties if possible. General Dung was ordered to allow a pause, offering the Americans time to complete their evacuation.

Seizing control

The occupation of the city began on the morning of April 30. Some South Vietnamese generals wanted to keep resisting, but at 10:24 a.m. Minh made a broadcast ordering his troops to stop fighting. As South Vietnamese soldiers abandoned their weapons and